

Managing Arthritis at Work: Practical Tips

Practical advice for managing arthritis symptoms while working. Desk setup, breaks, exercises and your workplace rights in the UK.

By **Living With Arthritis Editorial Team** · Reviewed by **Clinical Advisory Panel** (HCPC-registered physiotherapy & rheumatology nursing input) · 2026-03-08 · livingwitharthritis.org.uk

Arthritis at Work: You Are Not Alone



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Over 8.5 million working-age adults in the UK live with arthritis. Managing symptoms while maintaining productivity is one of the biggest challenges — but with the right strategies, it is entirely possible.

Know Your Rights

Under the Equality Act 2010, arthritis can qualify as a disability if it has a substantial, long-term effect on daily activities. This means:

- Your employer must make ****reasonable adjustments****
- You are protected from discrimination
- You can request flexible working arrangements
- Access to Work grants may fund workplace adaptations

Practical Workplace Adjustments



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Desk Setup - ****Ergonomic chair**** with lumbar support and adjustable height - ****Sit-stand desk**** — alternating positions reduces stiffness - ****Split keyboard and vertical mouse**** to reduce hand strain - ****Monitor at eye level**** to prevent neck stiffness

Movement Strategies - Set a timer to move every 30 minutes - Take micro-breaks: gentle wrist circles, shoulder rolls - Use the stairs (if manageable) for gentle exercise - Walk to a colleague's desk instead of emailing

Managing Flare-Ups - Keep medication at work (with manager's awareness) - Have a "flare-up plan" agreed with your manager - Use heat packs or cooling wraps discreetly - Know your trigger patterns (stress, cold, prolonged sitting)

Talking to Your Employer



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Many people fear disclosing their condition. Here is a structured approach:

1. ****Choose the right time**** — a private, scheduled meeting
2. ****Focus on solutions**** — "I work best when I can..." rather than limitations
3. ****Bring evidence**** — an occupational health report adds weight
4. ****Suggest specific adjustments**** — be practical and clear
5. ****Follow up in writing**** — document what was agreed

Useful Resources

- **Access to Work** (gov.uk) — grants up to £66,000 for workplace adjustments
- **Arthritis UK** employer toolkit
- **ACAS** guidance on disability and reasonable adjustments
- **Fit for Work** (NHS service) — free occupational health advice

When to Consider Reduced Hours

If full-time work is no longer sustainable: - Discuss phased return or reduced hours with your GP - Explore PIP (Personal Independence Payment) eligibility - Consider whether your role could be adapted rather than reduced

Written by Emma Richards, Occupational Therapist, NHS England

Q&A

Question: What is the key thing to know about managing arthritis at work: practical tips?

Short answer: Managing arthritis at work involves practical adjustments and communication. This includes using ergonomic equipment like adjustable chairs and split keyboards, taking regular breaks to move, and having a plan for flare-ups. Under the Equality Act 2010, employers must make reasonable adjustments if arthritis substantially affects daily activities. Discussing needs with your employer, focusing on solutions, and suggesting specific adjustments is key.

Question: When should I seek professional advice?

Short answer: If symptoms persist or worsen, pain is severe and unresponsive to usual relief, or you develop new symptoms, contact your GP, physiotherapist or rheumatology team promptly.

Question: Where can I get free arthritis support in the UK?

Short answer: Arthritis UK: 0800 5200 520. NRAS: 0800 298 7650. Free tools and guides at livingwitharthritis.org.uk.